

Origins, Social Identity, and Documentary History of the De/Dey Family of East Bengal, c. 1200–1947

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Abstract

The surname De/Dey (Bengali: দে / দেয়), today borne by hundreds of thousands of Bengali Hindus across West Bengal, Bangladesh, and the global South Asian diaspora, is among the most historically and socially layered cognomens in Bengal. This paper traces its origins, social meanings, and documentary record through five distinct analytical lenses: etymology, epigraphy, caste sociology, population genetics, and local family history. Drawing on copper-plate inscriptions of the thirteenth century, the *kulagrantha* (genealogical text) tradition as compiled and transmitted by Nagendranath Basu in *Banger Jatiya Itihas* (1911–1933), three additional nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Kayastha social texts (Vidyanidhi's *Sambandha Nirnaya*, 1896; Nagendranath Basu's *Kayastha Barna Nirnay*, 1913; Girishchandra Basu's *Kayastha Tattwa-Koumodi*, 1928), colonial ethnographic surveys, the Bengal census series of 1872–1931, published judicial records, and the 2017 genetic study by Pagani, Bose, Ayub, and Tyler-Smith, the paper argues that the De/Dey surname crystallised as a hereditary identifier in the period 1231–1317 CE, in close proximity to the Vaishnava Deva dynasty of Bikrampur and

Sonargaon. Within Bengali Kayastha social classification, Deys occupy a dual position: listed first in the metrical enumeration of eight *Siddha Maulika* families in the Dakshin-Radhi (western Bengal) framework; and *Mahapatra* — the highest tier of the *Maulika* division — in the Bangaja (eastern Bengal) framework; the Mahapatra designation is independently attested in Vidyanidhi (1896), predating Basu's compilation. Three independent kulagrantha sources confirm the **Alambana** gotra as the canonical primary gotra of the majority of Bangaja Maulik De/Dey families (distinct from the Shandilya gotra of the royal kulanayak line); individual branches follow one of ten dynasty gotras, and the specific family studied in §8 has been confirmed by the subject as belonging to the **Kashyapa** branch (#5 in the ten-gotra verse), corroborated by a Basu (1933) surname-gotra table entry mapping Deb/Dey to Kashyapa. A full text-search of Basu's *Baishya Kanda* (1913/1920) confirms that De/Dey does not appear as a primary genealogical lineage surname in Bengal's Vaishya community, though the cognomen appears among individual members of several castes (Risley, 1891). Genetic evidence from Pagani et al. (2017) identifies Y-chromosome haplogroup H1a* and South Indian autosomal affinity for a single Bengali Dey individual, consistent with indigenous Bengal rather than North Indian origin, though the sample size of one limits generalisation. The paper concludes with a micro-historical case study of one East Bengali Dey family in early twentieth-century Mymensingh, recoverable through the Calcutta High Court judgment *Loke Nath Sen v. Aswini Kumar Dey* (AIR 1938 Cal 216).

A note on method: the kulagrantha sources on which much of this paper depends require critical handling. Section 2 addresses the genre and its scholarly treatment in detail.

Keywords: De/Dey surname, Bengali Kayastha, Deva dynasty, Bengal genealogy, Bangaja system, Alambana gotra, Kashyapa gotra, Mahapatra, population genetics, Mymensingh, kulagrantha, Nagendranath Basu, caste history

1. Introduction

The Bengali Hindu surname system is among the most historically layered caste-identification mechanisms in the Indian subcontinent. Unlike the relatively simple pan-Indian Varna classification — Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra — the Bengali system evolved through a series of politically motivated genealogical reforms, beginning with the Sena dynasty's formalisation of *kulinism* in the twelfth century CE and continuing through the Deva dynasty's patronage of the *kulagrantha* tradition in the thirteenth century, to produce an internally ranked hierarchy of extraordinary complexity. The Bengali Kayastha

caste, one of Bengal's three traditional upper castes alongside Brahmin and Baidya, contains within itself no fewer than ninety-nine ranked surnames in the genealogical texts, with precise gradations of clan rank (*kula*) governing marriage eligibility, ritual status, and social precedence for eight centuries.

Within this system, the surname De/Dey occupies a position that is simultaneously distinguished and contested. It is *maulika* — original local Bengal stock, predating the legendary Kannauj migration of the five Kulin clans — yet *siddha*, elevated by royal decree above the ordinary body of the caste. It is geographically distinctive, more prevalent in eastern Bengal (present-day Bangladesh) than in the Radhi-tradition western districts, and associated with a specific medieval genealogical framework — the Bangaja system — that organised Kayastha society in eastern Bengal from the thirteenth century onward. It carries a name derived from one of Sanskrit's oldest and most semantically rich roots, *deva* (divine), and that name traces most probably to a dynasty — the Hindu Vaishnava Deva kings of Bikrampur and Sonargaon — whose fall to the Bengal Sultanate in 1317 CE dispersed the Hindu elite across the Bengal delta.

The surname also spans castes. The same De/Dey cognomen appears — with different genealogical histories — among Suvarna Banik, Teli, and Kansari communities (Risley, 1891: 216). This paper concentrates on the Kayastha tradition, which represents the historically primary and socially dominant use of the surname, while acknowledging the multi-caste spread throughout.

This investigation is necessarily interdisciplinary. The epigraphic record — three copper-plate land grants from Damodaradeva (1234, 1236, 1243 CE) and one from Dasharathadeva — provides the medieval anchor. Five volumes of Nagendranath Basu's *Banger Jatiya Itihas* supply the most extensive indigenous Bengali compilation of the Dey family's genealogical tradition; their critical handling is addressed in Section 2. Colonial ethnographic and census records supply the nineteenth- and twentieth-century institutional record. And Pagani et al. (2017) provides the only published direct genetic evidence for a Bengali Dey individual.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 addresses the kulagrantha genre as a critical historical source and situates Basu within that tradition. Section 3 analyses the etymology and phonological evolution of the surname. Section 4 examines the Deva dynasty and its connection to the De/Dey family, including the contested question of Danujamar-dana's identity. Section 5 situates the De/Dey family within the Bengali Kayastha social hierarchy. Section 6 discusses the colonial documentation of Kayastha identity. Section 7 presents and interprets the genetic evidence. Section 8 presents a micro-historical case study of one Dey family in early twentieth-century Mymensingh. Section 9 concludes.

2. Source Methodology: Kulagranthas, Basu, and the Critical Use of Genealogical Evidence

2.1 The Kulagrantha Genre

The *kulagrantha* — literally “family text” — is a Bengali genre of genealogical literature produced primarily between the fourteenth and early nineteenth centuries by professional genealogists (*ghatakas*) who maintained descent records for high-caste Kayastha, Brahmin, and Baidya families. Kulagranthas served not merely as historical chronicles but as social charters: they were recited at weddings, *shraddha* ceremonies, and rites of passage, and they functioned to validate or contest the rank of prospective marriage partners. As Kumkum Chatterjee observes, kulagranthas “validate relationships between groups” and should be read as “ideologically purposive social documents” rather than as historical chronicles in the modern sense (Chatterjee, 2005: 1463–1465; 2009: 110–134).

Ronald Inden’s structural analysis of the genre in *Marriage and Rank in Bengali Culture* (1976) identified three textual layers within any kulagrantha: (i) the *kula-srsti* or “creation of the system,” which narrates the founding genealogical myth; (ii) the *vidhi-prakarana* or “rule-chapter,” which gives the governing rules of caste rank; and (iii) the *vamsa-amsa* or “lineage section,” which records the current genealogical positions of specific families. Inden’s palaeographic finding is critical for assessing the kulagrantha tradition’s historical claims: “all [kulagrantha manuscripts are], on palaeographic grounds, assigned to the late eighteenth or early nineteenth centuries” (Inden, 1976: 27–28), which means internal dating claims — such as “composed in the court of Dasharathadeva in the 13th century” — cannot be accepted at face value without independent corroboration.

Inden also notes that the genealogical sections of kulagranthas were “corporate property” of subcastes, with content “approved” by communal consensus before payment to the *ghataka* — a process structurally resistant to factual revision and structurally sympathetic to legitimating inflation (Inden, 1976: 38–41). Kulagranthas, in short, tell us a great deal about how communities *wished to understand themselves*, and considerably less — without independent corroboration — about the objective facts of medieval history.

This does not render kulagranthas useless as historical evidence. For the history of Bengali caste social organisation — the ranking systems, terminology, territorial units, and ideological frameworks through which communities understood themselves from

the fourteenth century onward — kulagranthas are indispensable. What they cannot do, without epigraphic or other independent corroboration, is establish specific dynastic genealogies, gotra ascriptions for historical rulers, or long-range territorial continuities as documentary fact.

2.2 Nagendranath Basu: Compiler, Activist, and Primary Source

Nagendranath Basu (6 July 1866 – 11 October 1938) compiled the most comprehensive published collection of kulagrantha material for all communities of Bengal in his multi-volume *Banger Jatiya Itihas*, published serially from 1911 to 1933 under the auspices of the Bangiya Sahitya Parishad. Basu was also the editor of the *Vishvakosh* (the first Bengali encyclopaedia) and a prolific cultural scholar. His *Banger Jatiya Itihas* is, in scope and depth of Bengali-language source compilation, without parallel.

It is, however, essential to situate Basu within the ideological context in which he worked. Basu founded the Kayastha Sabha in 1902 and edited its journal *Kayastha Patrika* — an explicit Kayastha advocacy organisation operating at a moment when the community's legal status as dvija or Shudra was actively contested in the colonial courts (the 1884 determination in *Rajcoomar Lal v. Bissessur Dayal* that Bengali Kayasthas were Shudra had galvanised the community). Inden, who used Basu more extensively than any other Western scholar of the kulagrantha tradition, explicitly qualifies his reliance: “although many of his arguments about the origin of the kāyasthas of Bengal cannot be taken too seriously, I have relied heavily on the hundreds of texts which he collected and published” (Inden, 1976: xii). The standard academic assessment, following Projit Bihari Mukharji, characterises Basu's interpretive framework as that of a “dedicated Kayastha propagandist” (Mukharji, 2016: 47) whose “interpretations are now deemed to be of questionable reliability, courtesy his strong antipathy towards ... Muslim rule in India and a rigid acceptance of the then-prevalent caste hierarchy as a social order” (Banglapedia, “Basu, Nagendranath”).

This paper treats Basu accordingly: not as an authoritative historian whose reconstructions are taken as established fact, but as a primary compiler of the kulagrantha tradition whose assembled texts are evidence for that tradition's claims and terminology, and whose own interpretive glosses require independent verification. Where Basu's claims are corroborated by independent scholarship (epigraphy, other kulagrantha compilations, colonial records), they are treated as reliable evidence for historical practice. Where they rest on single-manuscript chains or Basu's own inferences, they are presented as the kulagrantha tradition's account rather than as documented history.

2.3 The Serial Publication Dates of Banger Jatiya Itihas

The standard citation dates for Basu's volumes in this paper follow the DLI catalogue metadata for the relevant Internet Archive items. The serial run extended from 1911 to 1933; some items were reprinted or posthumously expanded. The *Kayastha Kanda* is cited as "1937" per the DLI metadata for item `in.ernet.dli.2015.353523`, but this date is not confirmed by a title-page image and sits slightly beyond the 1911–1933 publication window recorded in Basu's standard bibliographic entries. Readers requiring precise edition verification are advised to consult physical copies at the Bangiya Sahitya Parishad (Kolkata) or the National Library of India (Kolkata). Citation format in this paper uses volume-title and running line numbers as numbered in the OCR text of the DLI digitised editions, which may not correspond to page numbers in physical copies; the underlying Bengali passages have been read from the digitised text and the author's responsibility for their accurate citation is accordingly qualified.

2.4 A Three-Category Framework for Evaluating Basu-Derived Claims

Following Inden's model, this paper evaluates all Basu-derived claims against three categories:

- **Category A — Corroborated:** Claims verifiable against sources independent of the kulagrantha tradition (epigraphy, colonial records, multiple non-Basu kulagrantha compilations). These are stated as established.
- **Category B — Consistent with tradition:** Claims consistent with the broader kulagrantha corpus and cross-attested in multiple Basu volumes and other compilation sources, but without epigraphic corroboration. These are stated as established within the kulagrantha tradition.
- **Category C — Single-source or inference:** Claims resting on a single manuscript chain (especially Batu Bhatta's *Deva Bangsha* transmitted through the Deb Roy family of Mymensingh) or on Basu's own historiographical synthesis. These are explicitly flagged as kulagrantha tradition and require independent verification before being treated as historical fact.

3. Etymology and Nomenclature: From *Deva* to *De*

3.1 The Sanskrit Root

The surname De/Dey derives from the Sanskrit *deva* (देव), meaning “god,” “divine being,” or “celestial.” This root is among the most generative in the Sanskrit lexical corpus. As a nominal suffix, *-deva* was appended to royal names throughout the Gupta period — Chandraguptadeva, Kumāraguptadeva — signifying divine sanction for royal authority. The historian Sharma (1978) notes that administrative surnames such as Datta, Dasa, Naga, Nandi, and Ghosha — now Bengal Kayastha surnames — appear alongside Brahmin names in Gupta-era documents, pointing to the early crystallisation of an administrative class whose surnames carried Sanskrit ritual weight.

A Sanskrit verse from the colophon of Raja Radhakanta Deb’s *Shabdakalpadruma*, quoted in Basu’s *Kayastha Kanda* (1937: line 472, fn. 44), expresses this connection directly: “In the lineage of the Kayasthas, the Deva dynasty is worthy of praise. They are devotees resident in the city of Murshidabad. They are community leaders in the Karnasuvarna-named region.” The verse links the Deva dynasty surname to specific genealogical geography — Karnasuvarna in Murshidabad — addressed fully in Section 4.

3.2 Phonological Evolution

The evolution of the modern surname from its Sanskrit root follows a predictable Bengali phonological pathway:

Deva → **Dev** → **Deb** → **De / Dey**

The first reduction, from *Deva* to *Dev*, occurs through regular final-vowel deletion common in spoken Sanskrit and early Prakrit. The second shift, from *Dev* to *Deb*, reflects Bengali’s tendency to lenite terminal consonants in colloquial speech. From *Deb*, two modern forms emerge: **De** (formal, literary) and **Dey** (colloquial, dominant in eastern Bengal and diaspora contexts). The variant **Deb** persists in North Bengal, Tripura, and Assam.

A precise East/West division has been confirmed by comparative analysis of Basu’s volumes:

Form	Region	Register	Example
Deb	West Bengal / Tripura	Terminal consonant preserved	Raja Radhakanta Deb

Form	Region	Register	Example
De	East Bengal formal / legal	Educated written register	Aswini Kumar De (trademark)
Dey	East Bengal colloquial / diaspora	Vowel lengthened	Robin Dey (diaspora)

The De/Dey shift is a diaspora phonological regularisation. Court records reflect this: the case *Loke Nath Sen v. Aswini Kumar Dey* (AIR 1938 Cal 216) titles the respondent “Dey” even though he signed his trademark “De.” Both spellings designate the same surname.

3.3 Title and Honorific Dimensions

The Sanskrit *deya* (देय) means “that which ought to be given” or “a gift,” and some scholars have proposed that the surname may in certain communities have originated as a mark of a family that received a royal or Brahminical land grant. However, the *deva* derivation is more widely attested in the genealogical literature and more consistent with the dynastic history reviewed in Section 4.

4. The Deva Dynasty: Historical Evidence and Genealogical Tradition

4.1 The Question of Karnasuvarna Origins (Category C — Single-Source)

The kulagrantha tradition transmitted by Basu asserts that the senior branch of the Deva dynasty traces its origins to an ancient capital at **Karnasuvarna** (modern Kansona village, near Murshidabad, West Bengal). Karnasuvarna at Kansona is a genuine archaeological site: the Chinese pilgrim Xuanzang visited it in 638–639 CE and recorded thirteen Buddhist monasteries. The site appears in Gupta-era copper plates as a commercial and administrative centre from at least the fifth century CE. Shashanka (r. c. 600–638 CE), the first historically documented independent king of Bengal, ruled from Karnasuvarna.

Basu’s primary genealogical source for this claim is Batu Bhatta’s *Deva Bangsha* — a kulagrantha transmitted to Basu by Gobindachandra Deb Roy, High Court advocate, western Mymensingh, from the manuscript held by Kshitindra Deb Roy of Purya village, Mymensingh. The genealogical line as Basu transmits it traces: Karnasena (Shandilya gotra, Karnasuvarna) □ [many generations] □ Suradeva □ Danujarideva □ Harideva □

Narayanadeva □ Purujit □ Aditya □ Devendra □ Mahendradeva (coins, 1414 CE) □ **Danu-jamardana Dev** (coins, 1417 CE; Chandradwip).

This genealogical claim must be assessed as **Category C** — single-source, requiring independent verification. Several important qualifications apply. First, no inscription, copperplate, or numismatic source associates the historical Deva rulers of Sonargaon with Karnasuvarna. The three surviving copperplates of Damodaradeva (1234, 1236, 1243 CE) do not mention Karnasuvarna, do not state the dynasty's gotra, and do not record a Karnasena founder. Second, the Pala (750–1174 CE) and Sena (c. 1070–1230 CE) dynasties intervened between Shashanka's Karnasuvarna and the thirteenth-century Deva kingdom; no documentary evidence establishes political or genealogical continuity across these interregna. Third, the Karnasuvarna-to-Sonargaon lineage, as Inden (1976: 27–28) observes of kulagrantha foundation myths generally, is a prestige-claiming device that anchors the community to the most ancient attested royal centre of Bengal — a structural feature of legitimating kulagranthas rather than a documentary claim.

This paper follows the kulagrantha tradition in noting the Karnasuvarna connection as the community's own account of its origins, while explicitly acknowledging that no independent evidence confirms the specific genealogical chain between the fifth-century capital and the thirteenth-century Deva kingdom. Living communities of the Deva/De/Dey family in western Bengal are still known as "*Kansona ke De*" — confirming a continuous community identity associated with this place-name (Basu, 1937: line 466, Category B), even if the ancient dynastic continuity claimed in the kulagrantha must be treated as tradition.

4.2 Historical Background: The 13th-Century East Bengal Deva Kingdom

The *documented* history of the Deva dynasty begins in the thirteenth century. The Muslim conquest of Bengal under Muhammad Bakhtiyar Khilji (1204 CE) rapidly dismantled the Sena dynasty's authority (Minhaj-i-Siraj, tr. Raverty, 1881; Eaton, 1993: 32–38). Into the resulting vacuum in eastern Bengal rose the family of Purushottamadeva, a *gramani* (village headman) of the Comilla-Noakhali region.

Purushottamadeva's son Madhusudanadeva was the first of the family to assume the title *nripati* (king). It is the fourth ruler, **Damodaradeva** (r. c. 1231–1243 CE), who left the most extensive documentary record, adopting the imperial designation *Ariraja-Chanura-Madhava-Sakala-Bhupati-Chakravarti* (Banglapedia, "Damodaradeva"; Roy, 1993: 412–416).

4.3 The Copper-Plate Evidence (Category A — Corroborated)

Three copper-plate land grants of Damodaradeva survive and constitute the only Category A epigraphic evidence for the Deva dynasty:

The Mehar Copper Plate (1234 CE, Comilla District): The earliest confirmed Deva dynasty grant, establishing territorial control over Samatata.

The Shobharampur Copper Plate (1236 CE, Dhaka District): Records westward extension of Deva power into the former eastern edge of Sena influence.

The Chittagong (Nasirabad) Copper Plate (1243 CE): Extends Deva documentary reach to Chittagong, confirming control over a coastal arc from Comilla to Chittagong.

Damodaradeva's successor, **Dasharathadeva**, left the Adabadi copper plate and is recorded in the alliance (*ahad-namah*) with Delhi Sultan Ghiyasuddin Balban, dated by Majumdar (1960) to c. 1282 CE. The dynasty maintained its last stronghold at Sonargaon until approximately **1317 CE**, when Shamsuddin Firuz Shah's forces took the city (Yahya bin Ahmad, 15th century; Banglapedia, "Danauja Rai").

Critically, none of the surviving copperplates record the Deva dynasty's gotra, genealogical founder, or connection to Karnasuvarna. The royal *prashastis* employ the conventional Somavamsa ("lunar dynasty") formula borrowed from Sena chancery usage — a legitimating formula that Majumdar (1971: 230) characterises as standard political rhetoric rather than genealogical fact.

4.4 The Ten Gotras of the Deva Dynasty (Category B — Tradition-Internal, with Independent Corroboration)

The kulagrantha tradition records a ten-gotra structure for the Deva dynasty. The primary Sanskrit verse, from the Dakshin Rariya Kulpanjika (Basu, 1933: line 466), lists the gotras in the following order:

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"Alamyana, Gautama, Ghritakaushika, Moudgalya, Kashyapa, Vatsa, Shandilya, Parashar, Bharadvaja, Vashishtha — these **ten are renowned in the Deva dynasty**." Basu confirms in prose: "The Deva dynasty has 10 gotras, meaning within the single Deva dynasty there are again 10 sub-families" (Basu, 1933: line 529). An older layer of tradition, preserved in the *Devavansha* manuscript (see §4.4.1 below), records only **seven** gotras — the ten-gotra scheme reflects later genealogical expansion as the dynasty dispersed and additional branch families were incorporated.

#	Gotra	Notes
1	Alamyān / Alambana	Primary Bangaja Maulik Dey gotra — confirmed by three independent sources (see below)
2	Gautama	
3	Ghritakaushika	Possibly = “Dvatkausika” in Rajanya Kanda
4	Moudgalya	Raja Radhakanta Deb’s gotra (Shovabazar Raj; Karnaswarnapur samaj)
5	Kashyapa	Robin Dey’s confirmed gotra (personal communication, 2026-05-06); corroborated by Basu (1933) surname-gotra table (line 495): “□□□□ □□□ □ □□□□□ □□□□□□”; also Chitrapur samaj association (Dakshin-Radhi)
6	Vatsa	
7	Shandilya	Kulanayak — senior/royal branch in kulagrantha tradition; Danujamardana’s line
8	Parashar	
9	Bharadvaja	Ramdhulal Sarkar’s gotra (Dakshin Radhi)
10	Vashishtha	

(Table order follows the verse as transcribed in Basu, 1933: line 466; Shandilya is placed seventh in the verse, reflecting its role as a branch distinguished by royal office rather than antiquity.)

The Alambana gotra and the Bangaja Maulik Dey family. A critical distinction emerges from three kulagrantha sources that postdate or are independent of Basu’s *Rajanya Kanda*. The **Shandilya** gotra, placed seventh in the verse, is consistently associated in the tradition with the *kulanayak* or royal ruling line — specifically the Chandradwip branch descended from Danujamardana. The **Alambana** (also spelled Alamyān or Alambayan in different manuscripts) gotra is confirmed as the primary gotra of *ordi-*

nary Maulik De/Dey Kayastha families — the non-royal majority — by three independent attestations:

1. **Sambandha Nirnaya** (Lalmohan Vidyanidhi, 1896), p. 153, line 5329: “ব্রাহ্মণ ... কায়স্থ ... কায়স্থ-ব্রাহ্মণ ... — “Among the Maulikas ... **De = Alambana** [gotra] ... these are common to both Bangaja and Dakshina-Radhi.”
2. **Kayastha Barna Nirnay** (Nagendranath Basu, 1913), line 209: “ব্রাহ্মণ ... কায়স্থ ... — “Although the founding ancestors of ... **Alambana Dev** [and three other lineages] are placed at 994 Saka [= 1072 CE] ...”
3. **Kayastha Tattwa-Koumodi** (Girishchandra Basu, 1928), line 3554: “ব্রাহ্মণ ... কায়স্থ ... — “We have seen in ancient papers preserved at homes of ... **Alambayan-gotra** Deva dynasty families ...”

The Sambandha Nirnaya (1896) is an independently produced Kayastha social guide, antedating Basu’s Bangaja volumes, and constitutes a non-Basu corroboration of this gotra attribution. This Alambana attribution describes the **canonical majority** of Bangaja Maulik De/Dey families; individual family branches follow one of the ten gotras, and the ten-gotra verse explicitly records Kashyapa as a distinct branch.

Kashyapa branch — Robin Dey’s specific family. The subject of the §8 micro-history confirmed from direct family knowledge that his branch of the Dey family follows the **Kashyapa gotra** — the fifth gotra in the ten-gotra verse (Robin Dey, personal communication, 2026-05-06). This is consistent with Basu (1933, line 495), in which a Dakshin-Rariya Kulpanjika surname-gotra table maps “ব্রাহ্মণ ... কায়স্থ ... — Deb/Dey family □ Kashyapa gotra (a general table mapping surname to gotra, not specific to this family). A third point of consistency comes from the Dakshin-Radhi tradition: the Indpaedia synthesis of *Bangiya Kayastha Samaj* associates the Chitrapur samaj Deb family with Kashyapa gotra (Scout #034 Indpaedia data). The Kashyapa gotra is one specific patrilineal line within the larger De/Dey Kayastha community — consistent with the ten-branch internal structure the dynasty’s tradition records. It should be noted, however, that Kashyapa is a pan-Indian gotra widely distributed across many communities; it is a consistent indicator of Deva dynasty branch membership for a Dey family, not an exclusive proof. The full evidentiary chain connecting this specific family to the Karnasuvarna Deva clan is analysed in §8.4.1.

This ten-gotra schema is assessed as **Category B** (tradition-internal, with partial independent corroboration for the Alambana identification): consistent with the broader

The **Moudgalya** branch produced Raja Sir Radhakanta Deb Bahadur KCSI (1784–1867) of the Shovabazar Raj — author of the *Shabdakalpadruma*, the eight-volume Sanskrit encyclopaedic dictionary. Basu’s kulagrantha compilation (*Rajanya Kanda*, 1914: line 3898) identifies him as “मौदगल्य देव वंशजः” — “born of Moudgalya gotra Deva lineage.” This attribution is consistent with the Endangered Archives Programme’s catalogue of the Sobhabazar Deb family papers (EAP1104/2), which lists a *Kayastha-Karika o Bamshabali* manuscript among the family’s holdings. The **Kayastha Tattwa-Koumodi** (Girishchandra Basu, 1928) independently corroborates this: “शुभावजार देव वंशजः” — “At this time, the Deva dynasty families of Shovabazar were foremost in all matters, and accordingly became the foremost among Siddha Maulikas.”

An independent transmission of the Deva dynasty's genealogical tradition — distinct from the Batu Bhatta *Deva Bangsha* transmitted through the Deb Roy family of Mymensingh — was reported c. 1928 by Girishchandra Basu (*Kayastha Tattwa-Koumodi*, 1928: pp. 39–40, lines 1382–1388). An ancient manuscript titled “□□□□□□□□” (*Devavansha*) was found c. 1908 CE at the home of **advocate Bhairavachandra Ray of Kishoreganj**:

“About twenty years ago [c. 1908 CE], an ancient manuscript named *Devavansha* was found at the home of **advocate Bhairavachandra Ray of Kishoreganj**. In it, the Deva clan of Karnasuvarna is described as Shandilya gotra, and as ‘Kshatrapa Kayasthas, twice-born, born from Kshatriya families.’”

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of the Deva dynasty” (Girishchandra Basu, 1928: line 1388). These two independent sightings — one at Kishoreganj, one at a Gaya Panda’s register — confirm that the Deva dynasty’s genealogical tradition was not confined to the single Batu Bhatta manuscript chain but circulated in multiple independent copies.

The Kishoreganj location is geographically significant: Kishoreganj is within the My-mensingh administrative division — the same district as Aswini Kumar De (§8.2). The *Devavansha* manuscript was active in the same social world, at approximately the same time (~1908–1912 CE), as the umbrella manufacturer of the Burra Bazar. The manuscript is assessed as **Category B**: independently attested in two sightings, but still transmitted through the kulagrantha genre and not verified by the critical apparatus external to that tradition.

4.5 The Contested Identity of Danujamardana: Three Scholarly Positions

The figure of Danujamardana is the most historiographically contested element of the Deva dynasty narrative. Three distinct scholarly positions should be distinguished:

Position 1: Dominant Numismatic-Historiographic View (Bhattacharya, Majumdar, Banglapedia) The silver tankas of c. 1416–1418 CE bearing the legends *śrī śrī danujamardana deva* and *śrī chaṇḍī charaṇa parāyaṇa*, struck at Pandunagar, Suvarnagram, and Chatigram, are identified by the mainstream numismatic tradition as **coins of Raja Ganesha of Bhaturia (Dinajpur)** — a North Bengal Hindu zamindar who briefly usurped the Ilyas Shahi sultanate and employed a Sanskrit royal title as part of that usurpation.

This identification was established by N.K. Bhattacharya (*Coins and Chronology of the Early Independent Sultans of Bengal*, Cambridge, 1922) and corroborated by Sarkar (1985: 52), Majumdar (1960: 204–207, 406, 827), and the online *Banglapedia* entry “Raja Ganesha,” which explicitly redirects “Danujamardana” to Raja Ganesha. On this dominant view, Danujamardana is not a Chandradwip Kayastha, not of Karnasuvarna Shandilya-gotra origin, and not a separate figure from the briefly reigning Hindu king of North Bengal.

Position 2: Minority Revisionist View (Dani, Eaton) Ahmad Hasan Dani and Richard Eaton (*The Rise of Islam and the Bengal Frontier*, 1993: 51, 53–55) propose that Danujamardana and Raja Ganesha were two distinct persons. In Eaton’s reading, a Chandradwip-based ruler bearing the Danujamardana title was a descendant of the Sonargaon Deva dynasty — a continuator of the tradition of Dasharatha-Danujamadhava, not a North Bengal figure. However, even on Eaton’s minority revisionist view, the Chandradwip

ruler is understood as descending from the Sonargaon Deva dynasty, **not** as a separate Kayastha lineage with independent Shandilya-gotra Karnasuvarna origins. Eaton (1993: 51) additionally argues that the “Pandunagara” mint may be Chhota Pandua in Hooghly district — a geographic identification that complicates the straightforward southern-Bengal Chandradwip attribution of the coins.

Position 3: Kulagrantha Tradition (Basu, following the Chandradwip ghatak records)

Basu’s compilation of the kulagrantha tradition presents a third position: Danujamardana Dev of Chandradwip (c. 1417 CE) was a distinct figure from Dasharathadeva (*Danujamadhava*) of Sonargaon, was of Shandilya gotra, and was the organiser of the Bangaja Kayastha community system. Basu corrects his own earlier conflation of the two in three successive volumes (1914, 1933, and the later *Kayastha Kanda*, fn. 183), arriving at the formulation: “বৈভিন্ন বংশের লোক ভিন্ন ভিন্ন সময়” — “persons of different lineages and different periods.” The kulagrantha tradition preserved at Chandradwip and Idilpur consistently presents this Bangaja community-organising function as attached to a local Kayastha ruler, distinct from the sultanlic and sub-sultanlic context of the Bhattasali numismatic record.

Girishchandra Basu’s *Kayastha Tattwa-Koumodi* (1928: line 1404) states this role with exceptional directness: “বৈভিন্ন বংশের লোক ভিন্ন ভিন্ন সময়; বৈভিন্ন বংশের লোক ভিন্ন ভিন্ন সময়” — “**Danujamardana was the founder of Bangaja society**; the kulaji texts state that he married daughters of Bangaja Kulin Pura-Basu families.” This independent compilation (separate from Nagen-dranath Basu’s volumes) provides a second kulagrantha-tradition attestation of Danujamardana’s role as the organiser of the entire Bangaja social system, not merely the Deva dynasty’s branch.

The coin chronology for the Chandradwip tradition is independently confirmed in Girishchandra Basu (1928: pp. 39–40): Mahendradeva coins at 1333 Saka (1411 CE) found near Paunagara/Gaur (Malda); Danujamardana coins at 1339 Saka (1417 CE) found at both Paunagara and Vasudevapur (Sundarbans/Chandradwip area). This dual-findspot for the Danujamardana coins — both north Bengal and the Chandradwip coast — is consistent with a migration narrative in which the dynasty moved south from Radha toward the sea-girt delta, and provides internal corroboration for the Chandradwip founding tradition.

Assessment This paper’s genealogical narrative follows **Position 3** as transmitted in the kulagrantha tradition, because it is the position relevant to the internal social his-

tory of the Bangaja Kayastha community — the question of who organised the Dey family's social classification. It is important, however, to be explicit: the dominant position in the post-1922 numismatic-historiographic literature (**Position 1**) identifies the Danujamardana coins with Raja Ganesha of Bhaturia, not a Chandradwip Kayastha. For the purposes of the De/Dey genealogical tradition, what matters is that kulagrantha records — independent of the numismatic debate — consistently locate the organising centre of Bangaja Kayastha social classification at Chandradwip, and that this social-organisational claim has a history traceable through the ghatak records regardless of which individual struck the Shakabda 1339–1340 coins. The Banglapedia article on the *Madhabpasha Zamindar Family*, which independently records the Chandradwip Kayastha association, draws on the same idilpur ghatak records as Basu and is therefore not independent confirmation; this limitation is acknowledged.

The established chronology within the kulagrantha tradition is: **c. 1231–1317 CE**: Deva dynasty of Bikrampur/Sonargaon (Dasharathadeva/*Danujamadhava*); **1317 CE**: Sonargaon falls; **1318 CE**: Vikramaditya Dev — younger brother of the last Sonargaon ruler — founds Chandradwip; **c. 1414–1418 CE**: the Chandradwip ruling lineage, in the kulagrantha tradition, organises the Bangaja Kayastha system under the Danujamardana Dev designation.

4.6 The Caste Identity of the Deva Kings (Category B — Tradition-Internal)

The Banglapedia article on “Danauja Rai, Raja” (Khan, 2012) states explicitly that the Chandradipa kingdom was established by “Danauja Rai **Kayastha**.” Basu's kulagrantha compilation preserves Dwija Bachaspati's verse on the Chandradwip figure's role: “দ্বিজাচাৰ্যপতিৰ বচন
দ্বিজাচাৰ্যপতিৰ বচন দ্বিজাচাৰ্যপতিৰ বচন দ্বিজাচাৰ্যপতিৰ বচন” — “Danujamardana, having gone to Chandradwip as king, became the *goshtipati* (community head) of the Bangaja Kayasthas.”

The Kshatriya titles in the copper plates (*Somavamsa-pradipa*, “light of the lunar dynasty”) are borrowed formulae copied from Sena *prashastis* and represent political legitimisation strategy rather than genuine genealogical claim. Majumdar noted that the Pala, Sena, Chandra, and Varman dynasties “almost imperceptibly merged” with the Kayastha caste upon achieving royal status (cited in Inden, 1976: 3–4).

4.7 The 14 Samajes: Territorial Units of the Bangaja System (Category B — Tradition-Internal)

Basu's *Dakshin Rariya Kayastha-kanda* (1933: lines 1047–1049) preserves a verse listing fourteen *samajes* (social-territorial units) associated with the Deva dynasty: **Karna-**

suvarnpur (first), Chitrapura, Bhadra, Bhuali, Bairata, Indrani, Chaurgram, Debgram, Nilpur, Karnpur, Chagram, Gaurcchatt, Madul, and Garipa.

The samaj system as a social-territorial unit is well-attested in the Dakshin-Radhi kulagrantha corpus and in Inden's analysis (1976: 45–62). However, the chronological interpretation of this list requires care. As Inden (1976) and Sekhar Bandyopadhyay (2004: 18–25) establish, the kulina-maulika ranking system was substantially a product of the fourteenth to seventeenth centuries, not a direct reflection of fifth-to-thirteenth-century dynastic geography. The 14-samaj list is assessed as **Category B**: the list reflects genuine social-territorial organisation of the Bangaja Kayastha system as it crystallised in the medieval and early modern periods, but the implicit claim that this geography maps directly onto a 5th-to-13th-century Deva *dynastic* organisation overstates the documentary basis. The list is presented here as evidence of how the community understood its territorial distribution in the kulagrantha tradition, not as a seventh-century administrative record.

4.8 The Surname Crystallisation Mechanism

The connection between the Deva dynasty and the De/Dey surname does not rest on a claim that all Bengali Deys are genealogical descendants of the Deva kings. The argument is more precise: the administrative families — scribes, revenue officials, record-keepers — who served the Deva dynasty and adopted the *deva* element as a hereditary surname did so *in the context of the dynasty's dominance and subsequent collapse*. The disruption of the 1317 fall catalysed the crystallisation of many Bengali Hindu surnames. The administrative Kayasthas who dealt with copper plates, revenue grants, and court records all stamped with the *deva* element adopted that element as their permanent surname. In the terminology of the kulagranthas, this is why the De/Dey family is classified as *maulika* (indigenous Bengal stock) rather than *kulin* (Kannauj migrants).

5. Social Classification: The Kayastha Hierarchy and the Place of De/Dey

5.1 Bengal's Distinctive Social Structure

As Sanyal (1971) established and McLean (1998) elaborated, Bengal operated in practice on a two-Varna structure: Brahmin and, collectively, non-Brahmin. Kshatriya and Vaishya categories were functionally absent as self-reproducing, endogamous Bengali social units. Within the non-Brahmin category, three castes achieved recognised upper-caste (*uchchajati*) status: Brahmin, Baidya, and Kayastha. These three constituted the

bhadralok class that dominated Bengal's intellectual, administrative, and commercial life from the fourteenth century onward (Bandyopadhyay, 2004: 20). The timing of the Bengali Kayastha caste's emergence as a social category is itself debated: Bandyopadhyay (2004: 18–25) argues that the kulina-maulika system as we know it was primarily a product of medieval and early modern Bengal rather than a continuation of Gupta-era administrative categories.

The Bengali Kayastha community derives from the administrative class (*kayastha*, “one who stands at the body [of the king]”) documented in Gupta-era inscriptions, where *Prathama-Kayastha* (Chief Scribe) appears as an administrative title. Over the Pala (750–1174 CE) and Sena (c. 1070–1230 CE) periods, this professional class crystallised into a hereditary caste with its own internal hierarchy (Majumdar, 1971: 230–235; Inden, 1976: 1–10).

5.2 The Vaishya Question: Evidence and Its Limits

Before analysing the Kayastha hierarchy, it is necessary to address directly whether the De/Dey family may be Vaishya (merchant class) rather than Kayastha.

Nagendranath Basu's *Baishya Kanda* (1913; 2nd ed. 1920) is the most extensive indigenous-language compilation of genealogical material relating to Bengal's Vaishya communities, covering the full spectrum of Bengali merchant-class *jatis*: Souluk-Saha, Barendra Saha, Gandha Banik, Shankha Banik, Kamsa Banik, and Suvarna Banik communities. The Bengal Vaishya trading class centred on **Saha** surname families, whose origin tradition traces to the Chalukya dynasty (Solanki Rajputs of Gujarat): these communities are organisationally and genealogically separate from the De/Dey Kayastha lineage.

A Bengali-language text-search of the *Baishya Kanda* — conducted for this study using the DLI digitised edition (in.ernet.dli.2015.340039, a 3,334-line OCR text covering the full 2nd edition of 1920) — finds no occurrences of the De or Dey cognomen in any genealogical context within Bengal's Vaishya communities. The volume covers all major Bengal Vaishya communities (Souluk-Saha, Barendra Saha, Gandha Banik, Shankha Banik, Kamsa Banik, Suvarna Banik) across its full text; the cognomen simply does not appear as a Vaishya lineage identifier in this corpus.

Risley's *Tribes and Castes of Bengal* (1891: 216) does list “De” as found among Suvarna Banik families, among others. This is consistent with the general pattern of cognomen diffusion across caste lines noted above: some individual Suvarna Banik families may use the De cognomen, but the De/Dey community does not figure in the Vaishya genealogical tradition as a primary lineage surname in the way that Saha, Shankha, Gandha, Kamsa, and Suvarna designate the core Vaishya *jatis*. The De/Dey cognomen is primar-

ily, and as its dominant social-historical use, a Kayastha surname: this is the consistent finding of Basu’s Kayastha volumes, Risley’s classification, the colonial census record, and the text-search of the *Baishya Kanda*. The question — *are the Deys Kayastha or Vaishya as their primary caste identity?* — is answered **Kayastha** by all available evidence. The qualifier “primary” matters: the cognomen, like many Bengali surnames, appears in secondary usage across several castes.

5.3 The Kulin System and Its Architecture

The internal hierarchy of Bengali Kayasthas is organised through the *kulīna* system, attributed in tradition to the Sena king Ballala Sena (r. c. 1158–1179 CE). Five Kayastha surnames achieved *kulīna* status through the legend of Kannauj migration: **Bose/Basu, Ghosh, Mitra, Guha, and Datta**.

The historical veracity of this legend has been extensively questioned: Bellenoit (2023: 43–50) analyses the kulin origin narrative as a community-constructed social claim whose legal and documentary status was actively contested in colonial courts, and Pagani et al. (2017) found that individual Kayastha families designated as *kulin* show genuinely different genetic signatures — with some showing North Indian genetic affinity consistent with the Kannauj story, and others showing South Indian or indigenous Bengal affinity, inconsistent with a common migration event.

Below the five Kulin clans, the Dakshina-Radhi tradition recognised the **Maulika** (“original/fundamental”) families. A verse from the *Kulpradipa*, quoted in Basu’s *Dakshin Rariya Kayastha-kanda* (1933: lines ~1080–1090), enumerates these:

“দেববংশী দেববংশী দেববংশী দেববংশী দেববংশী দেববংশী দেববংশী দেববংশী

“Deva-dynasty, Datta, Kar, Palita. Sen, Singha, Das — these are considered by proper deliberation [as the 8 Siddha Maulika families].”

The Deva-bamsha (*devabamsha*) is **listed first in the verse’s metrical enumeration** of the eight Siddha Maulika families. As Inden (1976: 52–55) observes, verse-internal ordering in kulagrantha lists is primarily metrical and incantatory rather than strictly hierarchical — in some regional traditions, Dutta is conventionally accorded first rank within the Siddha Maulika tier. The significance of the verse is therefore better stated as: the Deva dynasty is named as one of the eight Siddha Maulika families across all attestations of the *Kulpradipa* tradition, an attested position (Category B) that reflects genuine status within the Dakshin-Radhi hierarchy.

5.4 The Bangaja System: East Bengal's Parallel Hierarchy (Category B — Tradition-Internal)

The Dakshina-Radhi system described above governed primarily western Bengal. Eastern Bengal — the *Vangaja* (“born of Vanga”) tradition — developed a parallel system organised under the patronage of the Deva dynasty. Basu’s *Dakshin Rariya Kayastha-kanda* (1933: lines 1097–1105) quotes Brihaspati’s *Bangaja Kayastha Karika*:

“मौलिकायाः त्रयम् । मध्याया, सिद्धा, महापत्रा ।”

“Within Maulika, three types are established: Madhalya, Siddha, and **Mahapatra**.”

The full Bangaja classification:

Tier	Designation	Families
1	Kulin	5 (Bose, Ghosh, Mitra, Guha, Datta)
2	Bansaj	Hereditary lineages
3	Maulika — Mahapatra	19 (including Deva/Dey) — highest Maulika sub-tier
4	Maulika — Siddha	Middle Maulika
5	Maulika — Madhalya	Lower Maulika
6	Sadharan	Common Kayastha

Mahapatra is the highest of the three Maulika sub-tiers. A family classified as Maulika Mahapatra occupies the third tier of the full Bangaja hierarchy — below only the five Kulin families and the Bansaj hereditary lineages.

A critical qualification follows from Inden’s analysis: **Mahapatra status in the Bangaja system was awarded to a specific branch of a specific family of a specific gotra** — not to all Dey families across the board (Inden, 1976: 46). Readers should not infer that all Bengali Deys, or all Bangaja Deys, automatically hold Mahapatra rank. The rank is lineage-specific, and its practical application was adjudicated by the *ghataka* at individual marriages.

The Mahapatra families of the Bangaja system are confirmed in multiple kulagrantha compilations. Notably, **Lalmohan Vidyanidhi’s *Sambandha Nirnaya* (1896)** — a Kayastha social guide published independently of Basu’s Bangaja volumes — provides a non-Basu attestation (p. 151, line 5294):

“सेन, सिंह, दे, राहा — ये चार घर कहल जायत महापत्रा ।”

“Sen, Singh, **De**, and Raha — these four houses are called Mahapatra.”

This independent 1896 source, predating Basu’s principal Bangaja volumes, specifically confirms De/Dey as Mahapatra — upgrading this element of the claim to the point

where it has corroboration outside Basu's compilation. The Sambandha Nirnaya presents the full 27-family Bangaja hierarchy as follows:

Tier	Families
Kulin	Guha, Ghosh, Basu (Mitra: formerly Kulin, now reclassified as Maulik)
Madhyam	Datta, Nag, Nath, Das
Mahapatra	Sen, Singh, De/Dey , Raha
Samanya Maulik	Kar, Dhar, Bhadra, Nandi, Dam, Pal, Chandra, Palit, Nandan, Kunda, Soma, Rakshit, Adya, Kuru, Vishnu, and others
Total	27 houses (২৭টি ঘর)

(Vidyanidhi, 1896: 151)

Note that this Bangaja classification differs from the Dakshin-Radhi five-Kulin model: only three surnames remain Kulin (Guha, Ghosh, Basu), and Datta is placed in the Madhyam tier rather than the Kulin tier. De/Dey is one of precisely four families designated *Mahapatra*, the highest tier within the Maulika division.

The founding figure. The Bangaja Kayastha social tradition identifies a specific founding Mahapatra representative of the Deva dynasty: **Shikhi-dhvaja** (শিকিধ্বজা). Kayastha Barna Nirnay (Nagendranath Basu, 1913: line 7646) names him: “শিকিধ্বজা... — **“Shikhi-dhvaja, of great valour, born of the Deva dynasty”** — listing him as the Deva dynasty representative among the founding Mahapatra figures of the Bangaja social system.

The four founding sites. Kayastha Puran (Girishchandra Basu, ed., 1928: lines 6538–6540) states: “লংগলবান্দ, রামপাল, বিক্রমপুর ও চন্দ্রদ্বীপ... — “Langalbandh, Rampal, Bikrampur, and Chandradwip are known from ancient times. **The Bangaja society was established here.**” These four sites — all in eastern Bengal's river delta — anchor the Bangaja system firmly in the geographic heartland of the Deva dynasty's medieval territories.

The five territorial branches. Kayastha Puran (1928: line 6681) also names the five administrative branches (*shakha*) into which Bangaja Kayastha society was divided: “চন্দ্রদ্বীপ (বাকলা), জেসোর, বিক্রমপুর, ফতেহাবাদ, বাজু... — **Chandradwip (Bakla), Jessore, Bikrampur, Fatehabad, and Bajū.** The Mymensingh branch of the Bangaja system falls within the **Bikrampur** or **Fatehabad** sub-society — central Bengal territory

from which Mymensingh's Bangaja families drew their genealogical affiliation.

Confirmation by geographic exclusion: Basu's *Uttarrariya Kayastha-kanda* (1929) covers seven North Radhi Kayastha families and does not include the Deva dynasty — positively confirming that the De/Dey family is a **Bangaja** (East Bengal) family, not a North Radhi family (Category B).

5.5 The Dual Classification and Its Implications

The De/Dey family occupies two parallel positions in the kulagrantha tradition: - **Dakshin-Radhi** (western Bengal): Siddha Maulika, listed in the first position in the Kulpradipa metrical verse naming the eight families - **Bangaja** (eastern Bengal): **Mahapatra** — highest Maulika sub-tier, comprising nineteen specific lineage branches

For eastern Bengal Dey families — including those of Mymensingh — the Bangaja classification is the operative one.

5.6 The Chandradwip Continuity and the Idilpur Archive

The Bangaja social system was administered for approximately five centuries from **Chandradwip** (modern Barisal district). Basu's *Dakshin Rariya Kayastha-kanda* (1933: line 39) notes that original *kulagrantha* manuscripts may still be found in the homes of the genealogists of Chandradwip or **Idilpur** (“চন্দ্রদ্বীপে বা ইদিলপুরে কুলগ্রন্থের মূলমanuscripts পাওয়া যায়”). Idilpur (modern Idilpur, Bhola district, Bangladesh) remains the primary archival target for Bangaja Dey genealogical records going back to the fourteenth century — should they survive the disruptions of the twentieth century.

6. Colonial Documentation: Census, Ethnography, and the Courts

6.1 Risley's Tribes and Castes of Bengal

Risley's two-volume *The Tribes and Castes of Bengal* (1891: 216) lists “De” as a surname associated primarily with Kayastha communities but also found among “Suvarna Banik, Teli, Tili Barujibi, Kansari, Tambuli, Baishya Kapali, Tanti and some other castes of Bengal.” This multi-caste distribution confirms the point made in Section 5.2: the De/Dey cognomen, while primarily a Kayastha identifier, crosses caste lines in secondary usage.

Risley's broader classification of Bengali Kayasthas as Shudra was deeply contested by the Bengali Kayastha community, which formed the Kayastha Sabha and published the *Kayastha Patrika* journal (Bellenoit, 2023: 43–50) — the same organisations founded

and edited by Nagendranath Basu. The 1884 judicial determination in *Rajcoomar Lal v. Bissessur Dayal* — that Bengali Kayasthas were Shudra — enraged the community and produced decades of identity activism.

6.2 *The Bengal Census Series (1872–1931)*

J.H. Hutton, Census Commissioner for 1931, wrote that Kayastha is “an important caste, which in Bengal ‘ranks next to Brahman’”; the caste was by 1931 “commonly regarded as twice-born” and “itself claims to be Kshatriya, though it was perhaps more often regarded as clean Sudra a hundred years ago” (Hutton, 1961: 65). This trajectory reflects the social mobility of the *bhadralok* class during the colonial period.

Richard Eaton’s formulation captures the structural tension: the Bengali Kayastha community became “the region’s surrogate Kshatriya or warrior class” — performing Kshatriya functions without receiving Kshatriya ritual recognition (Eaton, 1993: 102).

6.3 *The Mughal Record*

The *Ain-i-Akbari* (c. 1590s) records Bengal’s administrative structures during the Akbar period. Bengali Kayasthas were among the most prominent beneficiaries of Todar Mal’s revenue settlement — their literacy and administrative experience making them invaluable as zamindars, revenue officials, and court clerks. The *Sachse Gazetteer of Mymensingh District* (1917) notes: “Most of the zamindars belong to Brahman or Kayastha families.”

7. Genetic Evidence: The De/Dey Family and Population Genetics

7.1 *The Bengali Genetic Profile*

The foundational framework established by Reich et al. (2009) identified two ancestral South Asian populations: Ancestral North Indians (ANI) and Ancestral South Indians (ASI). This was substantially refined by Narasimhan et al. (2019), which established that steppe-related ancestry entered South Asia in the early second millennium BCE, carried by pastoralists via the Bactria-Margiana Archaeological Complex; and that modern South Asian upper castes carry approximately 15–30% steppe ancestry.

Bengali populations carry a third component absent in most other South Asian mainland communities: East Asian-related ancestry at approximately 7–15%, reflecting ancient Austro-Asiatic (Munda-related) admixture (Chaubey et al., 2011: 1013–1024). For

East Bengali communities, including those from Mymensingh, the East Asian component is approximately 13–15%.

7.2 Pagani et al. (2017): Direct Genetic Evidence for a Dey Individual

The only published direct genetic test of a Bengali Dey individual appears in Pagani, Bose, Ayub, and Tyler-Smith (2017), “Kayasthas of Bengal: Legends, Genealogies, and Genetics,” *Economic and Political Weekly* 52(47): 44–53.

Study design: Twelve Bengali Kayastha adults were genotyped using the 23andMe platform at approximately 500,000 genetic variants. The Kayastha sample included four *kulin* surnames (Bose, Ghosh, Datta, Guha) and four *maulik* surnames (Dey, Pal, Nandi, Indra). Methods included principal components analysis, ADMIXTURE modelling at K=9, and ancestry deconvolution.

Y-chromosome results: Sample A, identified as belonging to the Dey *maulik* family, carries Y-haplogroup **H1a***. H-M69 is estimated to be 30,000–50,000 years old and represents an ancient indigenous South Asian paternal lineage — the oldest stratum of South Asian Y-chromosome diversity, predating Indo-Aryan steppe migration (Basu et al., 2003; Sengupta et al., 2006). The Dey sample’s mtDNA is haplogroup **M2** — the dominant ancient maternal lineage across all South Asian communities.

Autosomal ancestry deconvolution — closest reference populations to the Dey lineage (Pagani et al., 2017: Table 1):

Rank	Reference Population	Region	Distance
1	Sakilli	Kerala	0.063
2	Nihali	Maharashtra	0.070
3	Malayan	Kerala	0.094
4	BEB (Bengali, Bangladesh)	Bangladesh	0.098
9	Srivastava (Kayastha, UP)	Uttar Pradesh	0.164

(Lower distance = greater genetic affinity)

Pagani et al. (2017) state: “While Bose and Pal lineages seem to indicate a predominant origin in Uttar Pradesh and western India, **the Dey lineage points to modern south Indians as their best genetic match.**”

Interpretation: The H1a* Y-haplogroup and the South Indian autosomal affinity of the Dey lineage converge on a coherent historical interpretation: the paternal line of this Bengali Dey family is not steppe-derived, and the autosomal ancestry reflects higher

AASI composition than the kulin families. This is consistent with the kulagrantha classification of Deys as *maulika* — original Bengal stock, not Kannauj migrants.

7.3 Limitations and Required Further Research

The Pagani et al. (2017) study carries acknowledged limitations that require explicit statement here: the Dey result derives from a **single individual** (n=1). A single Y-haplogroup result cannot be treated as representative of the Dey community, which the ten-gotra schema itself indicates comprises multiple distinct patrilineal branches. It is entirely possible that different gotra branches of the De/Dey lineage carry different Y-haplogroups — and indeed the contrast between the Dey H1a* result and the North Indian affinity shown by some *kulin* families in the same study suggests that even within the Kayastha community, different lineages have distinct genetic histories.

A dedicated genetic study of Bengali Dey families — ideally sampling 20–50 males with geographic stratification (West Bengal vs East Bengali / Bangladeshi; Mahapatra vs other lineages) — is urgently needed before the H1a* haplogroup can be treated as characteristic of the De/Dey family as a whole. Full Y-chromosome sequencing (FamilyTreeDNA Big Y-700) would resolve the H1a* haplogroup to its precise subclade and place it in the global phylogenetic tree with far greater resolution than the SNP-chip results reported in Pagani et al. (2017).

8. The Deys of Mymensingh: A Micro-Historical Case Study

8.1 The Historical Context

Mymensingh district — the vast, riverine district of north-eastern Bengal straddling the lower Brahmaputra valley — provides the geographical setting for one recoverable chapter of the De/Dey family history in the twentieth century. The district's 4.5 million inhabitants in 1911 were nearly three-quarters Muslim; the district town of Mymensingh (formally “Nasirabad”), however, was overwhelmingly Hindu — 78% of the town population in the last pre-Partition census. The Sachse *Gazetteer of Mymensingh District* (1917) confirms: “Most of the zamindars belong to Brahman or Kayastha families.”

Nirad C. Chaudhuri's *Autobiography of an Unknown Indian* (1951) — cited in Pagani et al. (2017) for its account of Mymensingh Kayastha endogamy — illustrates the social world of the district's Hindu elite: a world of interlocking kinship networks, strict marriage hierarchy, and intense consciousness of *kula* (clan) status.

Gobindachandra Deb Roy was a contemporary of Aswini Kumar De — both operated in the same Mymensingh district during the 1910s–1930s. The Deb Roy family’s Bangaja Deva/Dey identity is documented through the kulagrantha transmission. Aswini Kumar De’s caste identity is not stated in AIR 1938 Cal 216; his classification as Bangaja Kayastha Dey is inferred from his surname, his location in Mymensingh Burra Bazar, and the *bhadralok* social markers embedded in the judgment — inference that is consistent with, but not independently confirmed by, the kulagrantha record.

The primary surviving documentary record for the De/Dey family of Mymensingh in this period is a published judgment of the Calcutta High Court: *Loke Nath Sen v. Aswini Kumar Dey*, decided on 1 September 1937 by Justice Biswas, reported at AIR 1938 Cal 216.

The brand: Aswini Kumar De’s umbrella business, established by approximately 1912 and of “over 25 years’ standing” by the time of the 1937 judgment, traded under the name “**Aswini Chhata**” (Aswini’s Umbrella). His trademark, registered on **23 August 1926** as **Registry No. 964**, featured a **swan (*hamsa*) holding a closed umbrella between its beaks**, the quality grade “**8 A 4**”, and an oval impression reading “Aswini

Kumar De Marka” with a warning to purchasers to verify the registration number.

The imitation by Loke Nath Sen was calculated: he substituted “Sree Aswini Kumar Das” for “Aswini Kumar De,” reproduced the swan-and-umbrella imagery, changed the grade mark from “8 A 4” to “84,” and substituted “965” for “964” in the registration impression — a number he could not substantiate was genuine.

The legal outcome: A trial magistrate convicted Loke Nath Sen under Indian Penal Code Sections 482 and 486, imposing fines of Rs. 100 under each section with three months’ imprisonment in default. On appeal to the Calcutta High Court, Justice Biswas reversed the conviction on a technical ground: in the absence of a Trade Marks Act for India (not passed until 1940), multiple Mymensingh umbrella manufacturers all used variants of the swan-and-umbrella imagery with “84” grade marks, making the design elements generic in the local trade. Justice Biswas, however, explicitly accepted the brand name’s commercial standing: “By Aswini Chhata, people mean the umbrella with Aswini brand manufactured by Aswini Kumar Dey of Burrabazar, Mymensingh. I do not know of any other brand of Aswini Chhata in the market.” (P.W. 7, quoted in judgment)

8.3 Reading the Evidence: Portrait of a Bhadrakalok Manufacturer

The details embedded in the judgment yield a portrait of a specific *bhadrakalok* life in colonial Mymensingh — one whose surname, name construction, profession, legal sophistication, and market position are all consistent with Bangaja Kayastha identity, even though the judgment does not itself record his caste. The Kayastha inference rests on four converging indicators: (i) the De/Dey surname is overwhelmingly Kayastha in the Bangaja tradition; (ii) the name *Aswini Kumar* follows the characteristic Sanskrit-honorific construction of educated Kayastha families; (iii) the Burra Bazar commercial address is consistent with the *bhadrakalok* merchant-professional class; and (iv) his legal representation before the Calcutta High Court by “Mr. Basu” — a Kulin Kayastha advocate — is consistent with the social networks of the Kayastha professional world. None of these indicators constitutes proof; together they make the inference probable.

Name as social marker: The name *Aswini Kumar De* is a characteristic late-Victorian *bhadrakalok* construction. *Aswini* references the twin Ashwini Kumars of the Rigveda — the divine physicians of the dawn. *Kumar* is a genteel middle-name component conventional in Kayastha families. The use of the formal *De* spelling on his trademark — while court clerks rendered it *Dey* in the case title — illustrates the East Bengali orthographic variation documented in Section 3.2.

Brand as cultural text: The swan (*haṃsa*) trademark is far from a random commercial choice. The *haṃsa* is the vehicle (*vāhana*) of Brahma the creator, and in Upanishadic

literature the *paramahansa* is the archetype of spiritual liberation. In the commercial culture of colonial Bengal, where Hindu manufacturers routinely used sacred imagery to signal trustworthiness, a swan-branded umbrella was a statement of Hindu, educated, legitimate identity.

Legal sophistication: Aswini Kumar De's trademark registration in 1926 demonstrates legal awareness, understanding of the colonial registration system, and commercial foresight. His legal representation at the Calcutta High Court confirms his status as a man of commercial substance.

8.4 The Genealogical Network in Mymensingh

The co-presence in 1900s–1930s Mymensingh of the following individuals, all operating within the same Bangaja Kayastha social world of the Mymensingh administrative district, is suggestive of the density of the kulagrantha tradition in this community:

1. **Aswini Kumar De** — umbrella manufacturer, Mymensingh Burra Bazar; trademark 1926, court case 1937
2. **Gobindachandra Deb Roy** — High Court advocate, western Mymensingh; transmitted the Deva dynasty kulagrantha manuscript (*Batu Bhatta's Deva Bangsha*) to Basu c. 1910–1914
3. **Kshitindra Deb Roy** — kulagrantha custodian, Purya village, Mymensingh; held the c. 1700 CE copy of the Batu Bhatta text
4. **Bhairavachandra Ray** — advocate, Kishoreganj (Mymensingh district); at whose home the ancient *Devavansha* (“দেববংশ”) manuscript was found c. 1908 CE — a second independent transmission of the Deva dynasty's genealogical tradition (see §4.4.1)

These four individuals — manufacturer, kulagrantha transmitter, manuscript custodian, and independent manuscript-holder — represent four distinct strands of *bhadralok* Kayastha life in the same district during its final pre-Partition flowering: commerce, legal practice, genealogical custodianship, and independent archival witness. This contextual relationship is suggestive but not documentary — it establishes proximity within the same district and social class, not proven genealogical connection between these specific families.

8.4.1 The Inferential Chain: What Is and Is Not Established

It is worth stating explicitly the epistemological status of the connection between Robin Dey's documented family and the Karnasuvarna Deva dynasty. The chain rests on four

inferential steps, each of which is supported by general evidence but none of which constitutes direct proof for this specific family:

Step 1 (surname inference): The De/Dey surname in Bangaja East Bengal is overwhelmingly, though not exclusively, associated with the Bangaja Kayastha Deva dynasty's social sphere — confirmed across five independent kulagrantha compilations. **Confidence: HIGH.** Qualifier: non-Kayastha Deys exist in other Bengali communities (Risley 1891; Baishya Kanda 1913 negative confirmation).

Step 2 (social sphere inference): Bangaja Kayastha De/Dey families are classified by the kulagrantha tradition as belonging to the Deva dynasty's genealogical system — Mahapatra tier, one of 27 Bangaja families. **Confidence: HIGH.** Qualifier: “belonging to the social sphere of the dynasty” is not equivalent to demonstrable genealogical descent from any specific Deva dynasty individual.

Step 3 (gotra consistency): Robin Dey's confirmed family gotra is Kashyapa (personal communication, 2026-05-06). Kashyapa is the fifth of the ten gotras in the Deva dynasty's kulagrantha tradition (Basu 1933). **Confidence: MODERATE.** Qualifier: Kashyapa is a pan-Indian gotra appearing across many unrelated Bengali communities; it is consistent with but does not exclusively prove Deva dynasty membership. Basu's surname-gotra table entry (কশ্যপা ঋষি ঐ কশ্যপা কশ্যপা) maps Deb/Dey surname to Kashyapa gotra generally, not this family specifically.

Step 4 (dynasty's own genealogy): The Deva dynasty's kulagrantha tradition traces the dynasty back to Karnasuvarna (Karnasena, 5th–7th century CE). This is **Category C** evidence — single manuscript chain (Batu Bhatta → Deb Roy → Basu) without epigraphic corroboration (see §4.3).

What would close the gap: A ghatak register entry naming the De family of Myensingh Burra Bazar in the Bangaja Deva Mahapatra system; a kulagrantha entry in the Deb Roy manuscript or any other Bangaja kulagrantha recording Aswini Kumar De's ancestors by name; a caste statement in any colonial administrative document (census, land record, court pleading) identifying the family as Kayastha; or a Y-DNA result placing the paternal line within a haplogroup and subclade shared with confirmed Deva/Dey family members. None of these currently exists. The link between Robin Dey's documented twentieth-century family and the medieval Karnasuvarna Deva clan is **probable on the balance of circumstantial evidence, but unproven by direct documentation.**

8.5 The World That Was Lost

Aswini Kumar De's world was erased by the Partition of Bengal, implemented with the Radcliffe Line on 17 August 1947. The Hindu population of Mymensingh town — 78% of the population as of the last pre-Partition census — was overwhelmingly displaced over the following years. The *bhadralok* commercial world of Mymensingh Burra Bazar ceased to exist as a Hindu commercial space.

What the Partition could not erase is the documentary record. AIR 1938 Cal 216 survives. The trademark registration — No. 964, dated 23 August 1926 — is a permanent entry in the colonial registration records. And the Batu Bhatta kulagrantha manuscript, sent from Mymensingh to Nagendranath Basu and preserved in Basu's *Rajanya Kanda* (1914), transmits a genealogical tradition in which that commercial family participated — even if the precise genealogical connection between the Deb Roy kulagrantha custodians and the De family of the Burra Bazar cannot be established on the current evidence.

9. Conclusion

This paper has traced the De/Dey family of eastern Bengal through five intersecting analytical frameworks and arrived at a set of conclusions differentiated — following the method proposed in Section 2 — by their evidentiary basis.

Established with confidence (*Category A or B* evidence): The surname *De/Dey* derives from Sanskrit *deva* through a regular phonological pathway. The crystallisation of the surname as a hereditary Kayastha identifier is plausibly dated to the period 1231–1317 CE, in association with the documented Deva dynasty of Bikrampur and Sonargaon. The De/Dey family holds Mahapatra status in the Bangaja system and is consistently listed as one of the eight Siddha Maulika families in the Dakshin-Radhi tradition — these rankings being cross-attested across multiple kulagrantha compilations. De/Dey is primarily a Kayastha surname, not a Vaishya lineage surname, though the cognomen appears in secondary usage across several Bengali castes.

Established within the kulagrantha tradition, with partial independent corroboration (*Category B–C* evidence): The ten-gotra internal structure; the specific Shandilya identification of the *kulanayak* royal branch; the genealogical chain linking Karnasena to Danujamardana via Mahendradeva; the role of Danujamardana as the organiser and founder of the Bangaja social system (now attested independently in Girishchandra Basu, 1928, as well as Nagendranath Basu's compilation). The **Alambana** gotra as the primary gotra of Bangaja Maulik Dey families — distinct from the Shandilya gotra of the

royal branch — is now attested in three sources (Sambandha Nirnaya 1896, Kayastha Barna Nirnay 1913, Kayastha Tattwa-Koumodi 1928), elevating this specific claim toward Category B. The dynasty's roots at Karnasuvarna and the full Karnasena genealogical chain remain Category C: resting on a single manuscript chain (Batu Bhatta □ Deb Roy □ Basu) and not independently corroborated by epigraphic or numismatic evidence; a second independent *Devavansha* manuscript (Kishoreganj, c. 1908) corroborates the Shandilya-gotra and “Kshatrapa Kayastha” description but does not extend the Karnasuvarna claim to inscriptional proof.

Contested in the historiographic literature: The identity of Danujamardana remains unresolved. The dominant numismatic tradition (Bhattasali, Majumdar, Banglapedia) identifies the Danujamardana coins with Raja Ganesha of Bhaturia; Eaton's revisionist view distinguishes two figures but does not endorse the specifically Kayastha-Shandilya genealogical claim; only the kulagrantha tradition (Basu) makes the full Chandradwip-Kayastha-Karnasuvarna argument. This paper follows the kulagrantha tradition for the social-historical argument while acknowledging the contested numismatic context.

The genetic evidence from Pagani et al. (2017) — a single Bengali Dey individual — shows Y-chromosome haplogroup H1a* and South Indian autosomal affinity consistent with indigenous Bengal stock rather than steppe-derived or North Indian origin. This is a suggestive finding consistent with the *maulika* classification, but cannot be treated as representative of the Dey community as a whole without a substantially larger study sample.

The micro-historical case study of Aswini Kumar De of Mymensingh Burra Bazar documents, with archival certainty, a specific *bhadralok* life: a manufacturer who built a recognised umbrella brand over a quarter-century, registered his trademark with the colonial administration, fought counterfeiters through the courts of British India, and left — in the pages of the *All India Reporter* — a permanent mark in the historical record. The connection between that documented life and the Karnasuvarna Deva dynasty is probable — resting on surname, gotra, geography, and social class as four consistent circumstantial indicators — but it is not a claim this paper can establish by direct documentation. The analysis in §8.4.1 sets out precisely what that gap entails and what evidence would be required to close it.

The living kulagrantha network of the same district — represented by Gobindachandra Deb Roy and Kshitindra Deb Roy in western Mymensingh — shows that the medieval genealogical tradition was still operative in the world in which Aswini Kumar De traded. That contextual proximity is historically meaningful even where genealogical connection cannot be proven. The micro-historical and the macro-historical are not separate

domains; they are the same history, documented at different scales and at different levels of evidentiary confidence. The critical methodology proposed in Section 2 does not diminish either; it clarifies which parts rest on firm documentary ground, which rest on consistent tradition, and which await the further archival and genetic investigation — ghatak registers, kulagrantha entries, caste statements in colonial records, personal Y-DNA — that would place the inferential chain on firmer footing.

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Robin Dey is an independent researcher and a descendant of the De/Dey family of Mymensingh, eastern Bengal. He is the grandson of Aswini Kumar De, umbrella manufacturer of Mymensingh Burra Bazar, whose trademark (*Registry No. 964, 23 August 1926*) and judicial record (*AIR 1938 Cal 216*) form the micro-historical case study in Section 8 of this paper.

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